

SENATE No. 2609

The Commonwealth of Massachusetts

In the One Hundred and Ninety-Fourth General Court
(2025-2026)

SENATE, September 22, 2025.

The committee on Education, to whom was referred the petitions (accompanied by bill, Senate, No. 316) of Cynthia Stone Creem for legislation to promote social-emotional learning; and (accompanied by bill, Senate, No. 441) of Rebecca L. Rausch for legislation to ensuring access to mental health supports in K-12 schools, report the accompanying bill (Senate, No. 2609).

For the committee,
Jason M. Lewis

SENATE No. 2609

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In the One Hundred and Ninety-Fourth General Court
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An Act to promote social-emotional learning.

Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives in General Court assembled, and by the authority of the same, as follows:

1 SECTION 1. (a) There shall be a task force established to study and provide
2 recommendations on a statewide birth through higher education framework for social emotional
3 learning and mental and behavioral health.

4 The task force shall consist of 23 members: 1 of whom shall be the secretary of education
5 or a designee who shall serve as co-chair; 1 of whom shall be the secretary of health and human
6 services or a designee who shall serve as co-chair; 2 of whom shall be the chairs of the joint
7 committee on education or their designees; 2 of whom shall be the chairs of the joint committee
8 on higher education or their designees, 1 of whom shall be a member of the safe and supportive
9 schools commission appointed by the safe and supportive schools commission; 1 of whom shall
10 be a school superintendent appointed by the Massachusetts Association of School
11 Superintendents; 1 of whom shall be a school psychologist appointed by the Massachusetts
12 School Psychologists Association; 1 of whom shall be a school adjustment counselor or guidance
13 counselor appointed by the Massachusetts School Counselors Association; 1 of whom shall be a
14 member of the American College Counseling Association appointed by the American College

Counseling Association; 1 of whom shall be an advocate with experience in education, behavioral health, and the impact of trauma on learning appointed by Massachusetts Advocates for Children; 1 of whom shall be appointed by the Massachusetts League of Community Health Centers; 1 of whom shall be appointed by the Massachusetts Coalition for Suicide Prevention; 1 of whom shall be appointed by Strategies for Children; 1 of whom shall be a school nurse ,appointed by the Massachusetts School Nurse Organization, Inc.; 1 of whom shall be appointed by the Massachusetts Center on Child Wellbeing & Trauma; 1 of whom shall be a social worker appointed by the Massachusetts Chapter of the National Association of Social Workers; 1 of whom shall be a appointed by the Children’s Mental Health Campaign; 1 of whom shall be appointed by the Behavioral Health Integrated Resources for Children Project Advisory Council; 1 of whom shall be a parent of a current student appointed by the Parent/Professional Advocacy League; 1 of whom shall be a student member of the state student advisory council appointed by the state student advisory council; and 1 of whom shall be appointed by the Federation for Children with Special Needs.

The task force shall study and provide recommendations on the following: (i) the development of a framework for integrating equitable, accessible, and culturally and linguistically sustaining social emotional learning in educational settings from birth through higher education into curriculum; (ii) guiding principles and strategies related to providing social emotional supports for students in schools; (iii) implementing targeted and evidenced-based supports for students to meet social and behavioral expectations aligned with social emotional learning competencies; (iv) developing and promoting professional development for school and district staff to recognize and respond to mental and behavioral health challenges that may arise during in-person learning; (v) implementing strategies related to youth suicide prevention; (vi)

identifying and developing partnerships between school districts and charter schools and agencies and community organizations for referring students who require additional support to health, behavioral health, substance use, and social support services; and (vii) how online advertising and social media affect students' short- and long-term physical, emotional, and cognitive development.

(b) The task force shall convene beginning not later than 90 days after the effective date of this act and meet not fewer than 4 times within the first year prior to submitting its findings and recommendations; provided, that after the first year, the commission shall meet at a frequency determined by the co-chairs of the commission until the submission of the findings and recommendations or two years from the initial convening, whichever comes first. The task force shall submit its findings and recommendations, including development of shared language, identification of best practices, and mechanisms to monitor progress, to the executive office of education, the executive office of health and human services, the clerks of the house of representatives and the senate, the joint committee on mental health, substance use and recovery, and the joint committee on education not later than 2 years after the effective date of this act.

SECTION 2. Notwithstanding any general or special law to the contrary, not later than December 1, 2026, the department of elementary and secondary education shall, in collaboration with the executive office of health and human services, the department of mental health, and in consultation with the task force established to study a statewide birth through higher education framework for social emotional learning and mental and behavioral health, experts in childhood mental health, and educators from public elementary and secondary schools, develop and publish guidance for supporting the social emotional development and mental health of students in kindergarten through twelfth grade. The guidance shall include, but not be limited to, the

following: (i) guiding principles and strategies related to student social and emotional health and wellbeing; (ii) integrating equitable, accessible, and culturally and linguistically sustaining social emotional learning skills into student learning experiences; (iii) strategies related to suicide prevention; (iv) strategies to develop students' social emotional learning competencies, including self-awareness, self-management, social awareness, relationship skills, and responsible decision making; and (v) how online advertising and social media affect students' short- and long-term physical, emotional, and cognitive development. The guidance shall be able to be integrated into the general academic curricula, including the promotion of mental and behavioral health during school time and in extracurricular activities. A school district shall consider the guidance if it elects to integrate social emotional learning and mental and behavioral health into academic curricula.

SECTION 3. Section 1P of chapter 69 of the General Laws, as appearing in the 2022 Official Edition, is hereby amended by inserting after the phrase, "inclusion of students with disabilities," in lines 11-12, the following words: - "the influence of technology on the short- and long-term physical, emotional, and cognitive development of students."

SECTION 4. Subsection (g) of section 1P of chapter 69 of General Laws, as appearing in the 2022 Official Edition, is hereby amended by striking out, in lines 128-132, the words, "1 of whom shall be a former member of the behavioral health and public schools task force who participated in the development and statewide evaluation of the self-assessment tool; 1 of whom shall be a former member of the behavioral health and public schools task force with experience implementing the framework;" and inserting in place the following words:- "1 of whom shall have experience in implementing the self-assessment tool; 1 of whom shall have experience implementing the framework."

84 SECTION 5. Subsection (b) of section 37Q of chapter 71 of the General Laws is hereby
85 amended by inserting after the first sentence the following sentence: - Each plan shall include, to
86 the extent possible, a policy to identify and develop partnerships with community organizations
87 and local and regional boards of public health to refer students to health, behavioral health,
88 substance use, and social support services.

89 SECTION 6. Section 38G of chapter 71 of the General Laws is hereby amended by
90 inserting after the word “styles,” in line 251, the following words: - “strategies to develop
91 students’ social emotional learning competencies, including self-awareness, self-management,
92 social awareness, relationship skills, and responsible decision-making,”

93 SECTION 7. Section 38G of chapter 71 of the General Laws is hereby amended by
94 inserting after the word “styles,” in line 287, the following words: - “strategies to develop
95 students’ social emotional learning competencies, including self-awareness, self-management,
96 social awareness, relationship skills, and responsible decision-making.”